

Order from chaos

For as long as I can remember, our anniversary issues have always heralded chaos (much more than our regular mad-scientists chaos at any rate). From planning what to do, to actually executing the ideas, it all feels like it's up in the air. Believe me when I tell you that until the last few days before print, the magazine is a mishmash of thoughts, suggestions, ideas, story pegs, and half-finished pieces swirling around in a sort of creative cauldron until a pattern starts to emerge. But then the magic always happens and these ideas start coalescing into what you are holding in your hands right now.

Creative bedlam aside, it is astonishing how small, seemingly insignificant starting points eventually transform into something spectacular. Like the time someone's random idea to try a Pixel Art cover, Robert's love for puzzles, and the prevailing idea for the month's theme being "something about security" resulted in a detail-rich cover and an even more detailed game that got you readers running through the magazine with a magnifying glass. This of course you now know as CTC.

Or the time when at a particular edit meet years ago, we were looking for story pegs for a Green Tech Issue. Someone, I can't quite remember who, was jotting down random words on a whiteboard, waxing eloquent about how a "seed" of an idea is needed. Ironically, I picked up on this and asked whether we could give out "seeds" with the magazine in the hope of sparking a tree-planting campaign. I knew it sounded nuts and I threw the idea out there with much trepidation, but I'm glad I did. We actually ended up giving away seeds with every copy of that month's Digit and hundreds of readers planted them. Pics of those jacaranda trees still make us glow with pride.

Being Digit readers, most of you must've already figured out that I'm hinting at Chaos Theory or what is commonly known as the Butterfly Effect. Mathematically, of course, 'Chaotic Systems' mean something much more specific; but as far as the pop-culture understanding of this theory goes, it can be described as the phenomenon of 'complex and unpredictable results occurring in systems that are sensitive to small changes in their initial conditions'. The famous analogy is that the flapping of a butterfly's wings causes a storm halfway across the world.

If you've been following my column, you know that I'm always interested in patterns, correlation and synchronicity. For my part, I've been keeping an eye out for these flutters within the realm of

technology as well. As fate (or chaos) would have it, an article that linked early RPG games, computer hacking and law enforcement popped up on one of my RSS feeds recently. It turns out, the way in which these disparate domains collided with each other through a series of random events is the reason why the Internet isn't a dystopian wasteland today.

In the late '80s the plot of a soon-to-be-released cyberpunk RPG game provoked the US Secret Services to initiate a raid on the company that was creating the game. So real was the plot apparently, that the CIA actually believed it to be a real conspiracy. In a sweeping crackdown, the company's PCs were summarily confiscated. Unfortunately, much like a raid on your own PCs would unearth some objectionable material, this raid turned up a document that was downloaded (I don't want to say stolen) from an unsecured BellSouth system. The document detailed internal practices of a 911 emergency calling system and became the starting point of a growing wave of hysteria – by any measure, the document wasn't critical; but what was portrayed to the world was that it could easily be used to take down emergency response systems in America. This was the early 90s, so you can imagine how esoteric all this must have seemed at the time. The CIA launched Operation Sundevil, almost a witch-hunt intended to burn hackers at the stake. The hackers, on their part, claimed collectively that their only crime was curiosity.

The ensuing lawsuits that followed changed the way the law perceived hackers – essentially, as people who had a bit more knowledge about computer systems than regular folks did. One of the turning points of the case was when it was revealed that BellSouth had included the same document (detailing internal 911 practices) in a booklet that was already being sold to the public for a few dollars! The witch-hunts ceased and curiosity wasn't treated as a mortal crime.

The trouble with these micro events is that they can only be identified in retrospect. I'd be curious to know if you've identified any of these "flutters". No matter how weak the connect, do send me your conjectures. 



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"An unrelated but interconnected chain of events is the reason why the Internet isn't a dystopian wasteland today"

Which issue did we do the pixel art cover for?

[Hint: You have the entire PDF Mega Pack at your disposal]

Answer format:
skoar.in/answer